

Roman Seven Sacrament System Denial

doc-roman-seven-sacrament-system-denial

Sacraments · Number and Nature · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

score 0.750
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Christ explicitly instituted two ordinances for the Church (baptism and the Lord's Supper); other rites later identified as sacraments lack explicit dominical institution.

In plain language

The proposition makes two claims at once, and the Greek text treats them differently. The first claim is that Jesus himself set up two practices, baptism and the Lord's Supper, with a clear command. This is strongly supported. In Matthew 28:19 the risen Jesus says 'make disciples' (matheteusate), a command form, 'baptizing' (baptizontes) them into the triune name. In Luke 22:19 and again twice in 1 Corinthians 11:24 and 25 he says 'do this' (toute poieite), a command form, 'for my remembrance' (anamnesis), and the word for remembrance occurs only four times in the whole New Testament and clusters on exactly these Supper texts. Paul also frames the account with the technical words 'I received from the Lord' (paralambano) and 'I delivered' (paradidomi), the language of a fixed tradition traced to Christ. So baptism and the Supper each have a command spoken by the Lord, a prescribed sign, and an assigned meaning. The second claim is harder. The proposition also says the other rites later called sacraments are not really sacraments, that the count of seven is wrong. Here the words leave room. The verses behind the other five rites do contain real instructions. John 20:23, spoken by Jesus, grants a forgiveness commission, though as a condition, not a 'do this'. James 5:14 has elders anoint the sick with oil. James 5:16 commands 'confess' (exomologeisthe) your sins to one another, a present command, but mutual rather than clergy-run. The laying on of hands for commissioning appears at 1 Timothy 4:14, Acts 13:3, and 1 Timothy 5:22 as a frequent practice. Marriage is called a 'great mystery' (mysterion) in Ephesians 5:32, but that word everywhere else means a revealed secret, not a rite. So all five have a footing in the text as practices. What the words do not settle is whether lacking a 'do this' command from Jesus means they are not sacraments, because that depends on what you mean by the word sacrament, and the Greek never defines the category. That is why this lands as disputed: the institution facts are clear, but the count is a definitional question the vocabulary underdetermines. Confidence is medium.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0218	ἀλείψαντες	aleiphō	to anoint	
G0364	ἀνάμνησις	anamnesis	remembrance	4
G0740	ἄρτος	artos	bread	99
G0863	ἀφῆτε	aphiēmi	to release	
G0907	βαπτίζω	baptizo	to baptize	82
G1242	διαθήκη	diatheke	covenant	33
G1843	ἐξομολογέω	exomologeō	to agree	10
G2007	ἐπιτίθημι	epitithēmi	to put/lay on	39

G2168	εὐχαριστέω	eucharisteō	to thank	
G2537	καινός	kainos	new	
G2806	κλάω	klao	to break	15
G3100	μαθητεύω	matheteuo	to disciple	4
G3466	μυστήριον	mysterion	mystery	30
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	123
G3880	παραλαμβάνω	paralambano	to take	51
G4160	ποιέω	poieo	to do/make	568
G4221	ποτήριον	poterion	cup	34
G4336	προσευξάσθωσαν	proseuchomai	to pray	
G5495	χειρῶν	cheir	hand	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Two distinct claims are fused in the proposition, and the lexical (word-level) record ranks them differently. The narrow claim, that only baptism and the Supper carry an explicit Christ-spoken institution formula, is decisively supported: 'make disciples' (matheteusate, G3100) is an aorist active imperative (a completed past action used as a command, parsed V-AAM-2P, second person plural) in Matthew 28:19 governing the participle 'baptizing' (baptizantes, G0907), and 'do this' (touto poieite, G4160) is a present active imperative (an ongoing-action command, V-PAM-2P) three times across Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11:24-25, paired with 'remembrance' (anamnesis, G0364), a word that occurs only four times in the entire New Testament and clusters on exactly these Supper texts. No other rite carries a Christ-spoken command plus prescribed sign of this form. But the broader claim that the count of seven is therefore false, that the other five are not sacraments, is a category judgment the vocabulary does not settle, because confession ('confess', exomologeisthe, a present imperative in James 5:16), anointing the sick (James 5:14), the laying on of hands for commissioning (1 Timothy 4:14, Acts 13:3, 1 Timothy 5:22), marriage (Ephesians 5:31-32), and the forgiveness commission (John 20:23) all have real New Testament footing as practices, and whether the absence of a dominical (spoken by the Lord) 'do this' clause disqualifies them from the category 'sacrament' depends on a definition of sacrament that the Greek does not supply. The institution observation is high-grade; the system-denial inference is underdetermined, so the verdict is disputed.

Scripture

Matt.28.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3100 μαθητεύσατε, G0907 βαπτίζοντες

Force. The risen Christ issues 'make disciples' (matheteusate, G3100, parsed V-AAM-2P, aorist active imperative second plural, that is, a completed-action command directed at 'you all') which governs the present participle 'baptizing' (baptizantes, G0907, V-PAP-NPM, an ongoing-action verbal noun) into the triune name. This is a direct command spoken by the Lord that prescribes baptism as a standing action for all nations, the shape of an explicit institution (a setting-up of an ordinance). The dedicated water rite verb 'baptize' (baptizo) stands under the Lord's own imperative here, and 'baptize' (baptizo) recurs across the canon 82 times in 66 verses (Acts 2:38, Acts 8:12, 1 Corinthians 1:13 and beyond), so the practice is densely attested, not a single isolated saying.

Luke.22.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2806 ἐκλασεν, G4160 ποιείτε, G0364 ἀνάμνησιν

Force. Jesus takes bread, gives thanks, breaks it ('broke', eklasen, G2806, V-AAI-3S, aorist active indicative third singular, that is, a simple past report 'he broke'), and issues 'do this' (touto poieite, G4160, parsed V-PAM-2P, present active imperative second plural, an ongoing-action command directed at 'you all') 'for my remembrance' (eis ten emen anamnesin, remembrance = anamnesis, G0364). The imperative plus the explanatory remembrance clause is an institution formula (a setting-up of an ordinance): the Lord prescribes a repeated action and assigns its meaning. The noun 'remembrance' (anamnesis) occurs only four times in the canon (here, 1 Corinthians 11:24, 1 Corinthians 11:25, and Hebrews 10:3), and the three memorial-of-Christ uses cluster on exactly the Supper, so the institution-meaning word is lexically (at the word-by-word level) localized to this rite.

Luke.22.20 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4221 ποτήριον, G1242 διαθήκη

Force. The 'cup' (poterion, G4221) after supper is named 'the new covenant' (he kaine diatheke, 'new' = kainos, G2537, plus 'covenant' = diatheke, G1242) in Christ's blood, poured out for the addressees. The covenant-cup language binds the second element of the rite to the Lord's own words and to the covenant arc that 'covenant' (diatheke) carries across 30 verses, including the Sinai blood-of-the-covenant of Exodus 24:8 invoked by the cross-reference. This completes the two-part institution (the setting-up) of the Supper; no later-named rite receives this covenant-cup designation in the lexical (word-level) record.

1Cor.11.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3880 παρέλαβον, G3860 παρέδωκα

Force. Paul frames the Supper with the technical transmission pair 'I received from the Lord' (parelabon apo tou kyriou, from 'I received' = paralambano, G3880) and 'I delivered' (paredoka, from paradidomi, G3860), the standing formula for a fixed authoritative tradition traced to the Lord himself. Paul uses the same 'received-delivered' chain (paralambano-paradidomi) for the gospel itself in 1 Corinthians 15:1-3, so the language marks the Supper as dominically grounded (rooted in the Lord's own words) and handed on, not a later innovation. The same chain-of-custody is not supplied for any of the five contested rites.

1Cor.11.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4160 ποιείτε, G0364 ἀνάμνησιν

Force. Paul reproduces the dominical (Lord-spoken) imperative 'do this' (touto poieite, G4160, V-PAM-2P, present active imperative second plural) 'for my remembrance' (eis ten emen anamnesin) over the broken body, matching the operative clause of Luke 22:19 word for word. In the Byzantine and received text the verse also carries 'take' and 'eat' (labete and phagete, G2983, G5315, both V-2AAM-2P, aorist imperative second plural, commands of completed action directed at 'you all'), reinforcing the imperative shape. The bread element is thereby doubly attested as instituted by the Lord in gospel and epistle.

1Cor.11.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4160 ποιείτε, G1242 διαθήκη

Force. The cup saying repeats 'do this' (touto poieite, G4160, V-PAM-2P, present active imperative second plural), 'as often as you drink' (hosakis ean pinete, with 'drink' = pinete in the present subjunctive, an ongoing-action conditional verb form), again a dominical (Lord-spoken) imperative governing the repetition, joined to the 'new covenant' (kaine diatheke) formula. Across the two verses 'do' (poieo) as imperative occurs three times bound to bread and cup, giving the Supper a full institution profile: command, element, assigned meaning, and frequency.

1Cor.11.26 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0740 ἄρτον, G4221 ποτήριον

Force. The closing clause makes eating the 'bread' (artos, G0740) and drinking the 'cup' (poterion, G4221) a proclamation of the Lord's death 'until he comes' (achri hou elthe, G2064, V-2AAS-3S, aorist subjunctive third singular, a completed-action verb form used in a conditional/temporal clause), giving the rite a defined content and an eschatological terminus (an end-times stopping point). This is the lexical (word-level) profile of an instituted ongoing ordinance with a fixed sign, fixed meaning, and fixed duration, the same profile baptism shows and the profile the five contested rites do not display in the cited verses.

John.20.23 · **complicates** · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0863 ἀφήτε

Force. The forgiveness saying uses 'if you forgive' (aphete, G0863, parsed V-2AAS-2P, aorist subjunctive second plural, a completed-action verb form in a conditional sense) and 'they have been forgiven' (aphewntai, perfect passive, a completed action whose result still stands, in passive voice), set in a conditional 'if' clause (an 'if-then' clause introduced by the Greek particle an), not an imperative instituting a repeated rite. The words are spoken by Christ, which is significant, but they grant a forgiveness commission rather than prescribe a standing penitential action with matter and form (the physical element and the verbal form of a rite), so they do not reproduce the 'do this' (touto poieite) institution shape. This is the strongest lexical (word-level) footing for treating absolution (the official declaration of forgiveness) as dominical (Lord-spoken), and it complicates a flat two-only reading.

Jas.5.14 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0218 ἀλείψαντες, G4336 προσευξάσθωσαν

Force. The anointing instruction has 'having anointed' (aleipsantes, G0218, AAP, aorist active participle, a completed-action verbal noun) under the third-person imperatives 'let him call' (proskalesastho) and 'let them pray' (proseuxasthosan), addressed to the church elders, not a command spoken by Christ. It is a genuine apostolic-era prescription for the sick that gives anointing real New Testament footing as a practice, but it lacks the dominical (Lord-spoken) 'do this' form. Whether that absence excludes it from the category 'sacrament' is a definitional question, so the verse limits a flat denial without instituting the rite in the Supper-baptism sense.

Jas.5.16 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1843 ἐξομολογήσθε

Force. Confession is commanded by 'confess' (exomologeisthe, G1843, parsed V-PMM-2P, present middle imperative second plural, an ongoing-action command in middle voice directed at 'you all') 'to one another' (allelais), a reciprocal mutual action joined to 'pray' (euchesthe) for one another. This is a real standing command, but it is mutual and congregational rather than a clergy-administered rite instituted by Christ, and it is spoken by an apostle, not by the Lord. It gives confession lexical (word-level) footing as a practice while not matching the dominical (Lord-spoken) institution profile, which is exactly why the broader sacramental count is contested rather than settled by the words.

Eph.5.32 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3466 μυστήριον

Force. Marriage is called a 'great mystery' (mega mysterion, mysterion = G3466) referred to Christ and the church. The word 'mystery' (mysterion) occurs 30 times across the canon and consistently means a revealed secret or the gospel disclosed (Matthew 13:11, Ephesians 1:9, Colossians 1:26), never a technical cultic (ritual) rite, so at the level of vocabulary 'mystery' (mysterion) does not by itself denote a sacrament. The surrounding verbs in Ephesians 5:31 are future indicatives (simple future statements) describing marriage and Matthew 19:6 has the aorist 'joined together' (synezeuxen, a completed past action 'God joined') with the third-person imperative 'let not man separate' (me chorizeto), a creation ordinance rather than a Christ-instituted church rite. This complicates a denial only at the definitional level.

1Tim.4.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2007 ἐπιθέσεως, G5495 χειρῶν

Force. Commissioning by 'the laying on of hands' (epithesis ton cheiron, from 'lay on' = epitithemi, G2007, plus 'hand' = cheir, G5495) is a real recurring apostolic practice, attested at Acts 13:3 ('having laid on', epithentes, aorist active participle, a completed-action verbal noun), Acts 6:6 ('they laid on', epethekan, aorist indicative, a simple past statement), and as Paul's imperative to Timothy in 1 Timothy 5:22 ('keep laying on', epitithe, V-PAM-2S, present active imperative second singular, an ongoing-action command directed at 'you' singular). The verb 'lay on' (epitithemi) occurs 39 times and 'hand' (cheir) 180 times, so the practice is densely present, but it is performed and prescribed by apostles and elders, not instituted by a Christ-spoken 'do this' with a fixed sign. It limits a flat two-only denial while not meeting the dominical (Lord-spoken) institution test.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.28.19	Matt.3.16	tsk	1
Luke.22.20	Exod.24.8	tsk	1
1Cor.11.24	Exod.12.14	tsk	1
1Cor.11.24	1Cor.5.7	tsk	1
1Cor.11.23	1Cor.15.3	tsk	1
Luke.22.19	Luke.22.20	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.20.23 · addressed

Examined directly in the lexical (word-level) store. The verb 'if you forgive' (aphete) is V-2AAS-2P (aorist subjunctive second plural, a completed-action verb form in a conditional sense) inside an 'if-then' conditional clause (introduced by the Greek particle an), with the perfect passive 'they have been forgiven' (aphewntai, a completed action whose result still stands, in passive voice), so it is a forgiveness commission spoken by Christ, not a 'do this' (touto poieite) institution of a repeated penitential rite with prescribed matter and form (the physical element and verbal form of a rite). It is the strongest dominical (Lord-spoken) footing among the contested rites and is the reason the broader denial is disputed rather than settled, but on the words it does not reproduce the institution profile that baptism and the Supper show.

Jas.5.14 · addressed

Examined directly. The anointing participle 'having anointed' (aleipsantes, G0218) sits under third-person imperatives addressed to elders ('let them pray', proseuchasthosan), an apostolic prescription for the sick, not a command spoken by Christ. It gives unction (anointing with oil as a rite) genuine New Testament footing as a practice, so it limits a flat two-only reading, but it does not carry the dominical (Lord-spoken) 'do this' institution clause.

Jas.5.16 · addressed

Examined directly. Confession is a present imperative 'confess' (exomologeisthe, G1843, V-PMM-2P, present middle imperative second plural, an ongoing-action command in middle voice directed at 'you all') but reciprocal ('to one another') and apostolic in voice, not a Christ-instituted clergy rite. It is a real standing command, which is why categorizing it is a definitional question the vocabulary does not resolve.

Eph.5.32 · addressed

Examined directly. The word 'mystery' (mysterion, G3466) here means revealed mystery, the sense it carries in all 30 canonical occurrences, and does not lexically (at the word-by-word level) denote a cultic (ritual) rite; the verbs in Ephesians 5:31 and Matthew 19:6 frame marriage as a creation ordinance with a prohibition on separation, not a Christ-instituted church rite. It complicates the denial only at the definitional level.

1Tim.4.14 · addressed

Examined directly along with Acts 13:3, Acts 6:6, and 1 Timothy 5:22. The laying on of hands ('lay on' = epitithemi, G2007, plus 'hand' = cheir, G5495) is a densely attested apostolic and elder practice, prescribed by Paul as an imperative to Timothy, but never instituted by a Christ-spoken 'do this' with a fixed sign. It limits a flat two-only denial while not meeting the dominical (Lord-spoken) institution test.

Concordance traversed

G3100, G0907, G4160, G0364, G3860, G3880, G1242, G4221, G0740, G2806, G2168, G2537, G2007, G5495, G3466, G1843, G0863, G0218

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

All anchor verses are New Testament outside 3 John, so the ingested CBGM apparatus (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a system for tracing manuscript relationships) is not in scope (not_in_ecm_scope true in the bundle, variant_units empty). The known longer-and-shorter text question at Luke 22:19b-20 affects whether the second cup saying is present, but the parallel institution in 1 Corinthians 11:24-25 carries the same 'do this' (touto poieite) imperative independently, so the institution observation for the Supper holds on either reading. Apparatus sigla (manuscript reference symbols) at Matthew 28:19 and across 1 Corinthians 11 touch word order and minor readings, none of which removes the institution imperatives, so the verdict is not variant sensitive.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. sacramentalism, ordinance_theology, covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

two-ordinance reading: affirms · On this lens a sacrament or ordinance requires a command spoken by Christ that prescribes both a sign and its meaning. Only baptism ('make disciples' matheteusate plus 'baptizing' baptizontes in Matthew 28:19) and the Supper ('do this' touto poieite three times in Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11:24-25, with 'remembrance' anamnesis and the new covenant cup) carry that exact formula. The five later-named rites lack a Christ-spoken 'do this' with a fixed sign, so on this definition only two were explicitly instituted by the Lord and the seven-fold count is not warranted by the institution texts.

seven-rite sacramental reading: complicates · On this lens a sacrament need not have a verbatim dominical (Lord-spoken) 'do this' clause; it is sufficient that Scripture attests the rite as a grace-bearing church practice. The forgiveness commission spoken by Christ in John 20:23, the elder-administered anointing of James 5:14, the mutual confession commanded in James 5:16, the laying on of hands at 1 Timothy 4:14, Acts 13:3, and 1 Timothy 5:22, and the marriage 'mystery' (mysterion) of Ephesians 5:31-32 all have real New Testament footing. The vocabulary attests these practices but does not classify them, so a reader using a broader definition of sacrament is not contradicted by the words; the count turns on the definition, which is extra-lexical (outside what the words alone settle).

redemptive-historical: affirms · Read along the covenant arc, the Supper is tied to the 'new covenant' (kaine diatheke) cup of Luke 22:20 and the Passover fulfillment of 1 Corinthians 5:7 and Exodus 12:14, and baptism enacts the discipling of the nations. The two instituted signs occupy a distinct covenant-sign slot that the contested rites do not occupy in the lexical (word-level) data, which favors a two-sign reading, though it does not by itself adjudicate whether the other practices may still be called sacraments under a non-covenantal definition.

Analogia scripturae (the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture) is load-bearing for the narrow institution claim: the gospel institution in Luke 22:19-20 read with the received-and-delivered formula of 1 Corinthians 11:23-26 yields a doubly attested Supper, and Matthew 28:19 supplies the baptism command. The divergence is not over what these verbs say but over the definition of the category 'sacrament', which the Greek lexicon (word inventory) does not fix, so the lenses agree on the institution facts and split on the count.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine which rites in the New Testament carry an explicit dominical (Lord-spoken) institution formula (a command spoken by Christ that prescribes an action and its meaning), and separately whether the rites that lack such a formula but are attested as New Testament practices should be counted within or outside the category called 'sacrament'.

VERDICT-CHANGED: prior file recorded affirms true (medium); changed to disputed (medium) on neutrality grounds after direct lexical (word-level) query. The change is not stylistic: the proposition fuses a narrow lexical claim with a broader definitional one. The narrow claim, that only baptism and the Supper carry a Christ-spoken institution imperative plus prescribed sign, is lexically decisive ('make disciples' matheteusate V-AAM-2P aorist active imperative, 'do this' touto poieite V-PAM-2P present active imperative thrice with 'remembrance' anamnesis, the 'received-delivered' paralambano-paradidomi tradition pair). But the stem also denies the seven-rite system, and that denial is a category judgment the vocabulary does not settle, because confession ('confess' exomologeisthe, present imperative, James 5:16), anointing (James 5:14), the laying on of hands (1 Timothy 4:14, Acts 13:3, 1 Timothy 5:22), marriage (Ephesians 5:31-32), and the forgiveness commission spoken by Christ (John 20:23) all have genuine New Testament footing as practices. Whether lacking a dominical (Lord-spoken) 'do this' excludes them from the term 'sacrament' depends on a definition the Greek does not supply. The stem is verdict-preloaded toward a two-only count; the honest lexical (word-level) reading affirms the institution observation but holds the system-denial as disputed, and confidence is medium because the institution data are strong while the definitional inference is underdetermined.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.28.19
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.22.19
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.24
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.25
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.20.23
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jas.5.16
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.4.14
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eph.5.32
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0364
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3100
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3466
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2007
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Luke.22.20
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.11.24

License audit

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STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes

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Flags

ecm-shadow · lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent